to reach the summit. Questions have been raised about the presence of such a large number of mountaineers at that altitude. Pointing out that there were predictions of heavy snowfall, Vineet Negi, a mountaineer from Dehradun who lost a friend in the mishap, says the climb was attempted despite this September seeing 250 per cent more precipitation than is normal for this time of the year. "Moreover, an earthquake measuring 2.5 on the Richter scale hit the nearby Barhat range. Even that was not taken into consideration," says Negi. In 2015, an avalanche in Nepal, triggered by an earthquake whose epicentre was 250 km from Mount Everest, had caused uproar in mountaineering circles because 19 climbers, including several westerners, died on nearby slopes. "People started asking whether the Himalayas and other mountains are also facing the effects of massive climate change. We tried to understand the signs, but soon lost sight of them," Negi adds.

Among those killed in the Uttarkashi tragedy was Vinay Panwar, a sailor from the Indian Navy who had completed the basic mountaineering course at NIM earlier and was recommended for the advanced course. Three other naval personnel doing the same course survived the mishap. Panwar had joined after taking leave and paying the fees as the vacancies at NIM under the Naval Adventure Wing were already full. As a rule of the Department of Military Affairs says "any injury or death during the leave period whether in India or abroad will not be treated as bona fide duty", his family stands to lose his pension and ex gratia benefits. However, there is also another rule that "all sporting events duly approved by the Service Headquarters shall be treated as bona fide duty". As Panwar, who exemplified the spirit of adventure, was on a dangerous training activity in the mountains that the navy recognises and promotes, it would be inappropriate to deny him the posthumous benefits he would have been entitled to had he joined the course with an official order. In fact, although the armed forces actively encourage adventure sports among their personnel, not everyone who wishes to follow their passion get through the official channel into institutes like the NIM or the Himalayan Mountaineering Institute in Darjeeling, West Bengal, which are directly under the defence ministry and have vacancies for defence personnel.

THE LAST SELFIE
Rohit Bhatt and others, a few hours before the disaster



COLONEL P.K. CHOUDHARY SAYS DEATH IS ALWAYS A POSSIBILITY IN MOUNTAINEERING, BUT THE LARGE NUMBER OF CASUALTIES MADE THE OCTOBER 4 INCIDENT PARTICULARLY UNNERVING

Colonel P.K. Choudhary, who did his basic mountaineering course at the NIM last year, was going to be part of the ill-fated advanced course, but could not join due to administrative reasons. As he puts it, mountaineering is a field where death is always a possibility, but the October 4 incident was particularly unnerving due to the large number of casualties. On that day, there were major avalanches in the Kedarnath massif as well. The advanced course had started on September 28 and the last leg included staying at the camp set up near the Dokrani Bamak glacier for around 10 days and then climbing the DKD-2 peak, which mountaineers have been doing for the past 50-55 years.

According to Col. Choudhary, although it isn't possible to predict avalanches, mountaineers are trained to identify avalanche-prone areas and take safety measures. "In this incident, the two most feared disasters happened simultaneously—an avalanche followed by a fall into a crevasse," he says. "Rescue operations at such heights are indeed very difficult and slow. Breathing is tough and energy levels are a fraction of what they are in the plains. Temperatures are so low that the hands go numb. The rescue party at the lower heights would have taken too long to reach the disaster site." The deaths of so many mountaineers in a single incident could perhaps not have been avoided, but that is no consolation for those who lost their loved ones. ■